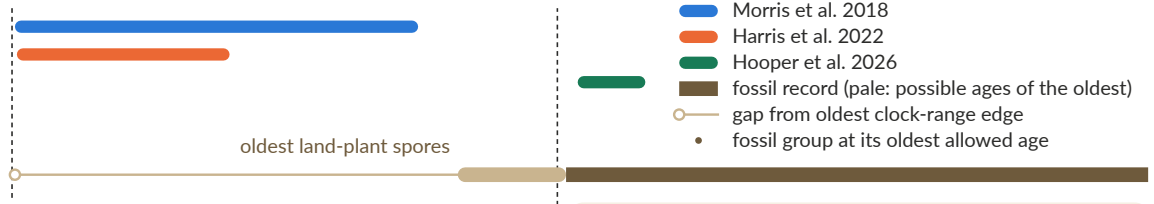
Ancestor of all living land plants



Libyan boreholes: samples with three-rayed (trilete) spores



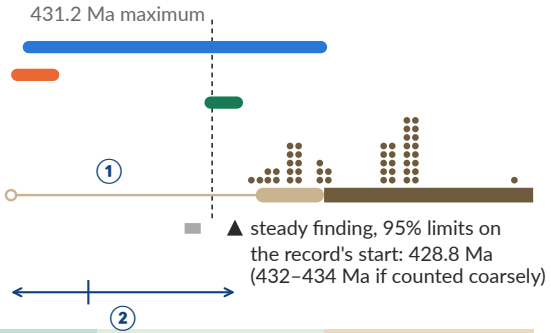
0 of 28 older

51 of 59 younger than ~443 Ma

A steady input since 459.1 Ma fits only below 0.09 of the later input (0.39 if samples are weighted by well and rock unit)

Ancestor of living vascular plants

clubmosses, ferns, seed plants



Two examples in which older clock dates (444–452 Ma) fit:

① no delay in recognisable features; fossils found 8–12× less often before the oldest one than after it

② fossils found at a steady rate; recognisable features appearing at least 15–23 million years after the ancestor

Both count the 48 fossil groups as independent; counted coarsely, ① needs 2.4–4.5×. They show what fits, not how common the plants were.

